The cardinal reached a second door without perceiving he was being followed; the sand with which the alleys were covered deadened the sound of footsteps.

He then turned to the left, down a corridor which had escaped the attention of the two friends, but as he opened the door he paused, as if in thought.

'Ah! *Diavolo!*' he exclaimed, 'I forgot the recommendation of De Comminges, who advised me to take a guard and place it at this door, in order not to put myself at the mercy of that four-headed combination of devils.' And with a movement of impatience he turned to retrace his steps.

'Do not give yourself the trouble, my lord,' said D'Artagnan, with his right foot forward, his beaver in his hand, a smile on his face, 'we have followed your eminence step by step and here we are.'

'Yes—*here* we are,' said Porthos.

And he made the same friendly salute as D'Artagnan.

Mazarin gazed at each of them with an affrighted stare, recognised them, and let drop his lantern, uttering a cry of terror.

D'Artagnan picked it up; by good luck it had not been extinguished.

'Oh, what imprudence, my lord,' said D'Artagnan; ''tis not good to be about just here without a light. Your eminence might knock against something, or fall into a hole.'

'Monsieur d'Artagnan!' muttered Mazarin, unable to recover from his astonishment.

'Yes, my lord, it is I. I have the honour to present to you Monsieur du Vallon, that excellent friend of mine, in whom your eminence had the kindness to interest yourself formerly.'

And D'Artagnan held the lamp before the merry face of Porthos, who now began to comprehend the affair and be very proud of the whole undertaking.

'You were going to visit Monsieur de la Fère?' said D'Artagnan. 'Don't let us disarrange your eminence. Be so good as to show us the way and we will follow you.'

Mazarin was by degrees recovering his senses.

'Have you been long in the orangery?' he asked in a trembling voice, remembering the visits he had been paying to his treasury.

Porthos opened his mouth to reply; D'Artagnan made him a sign, and his mouth, remaining silent, gradually closed.

'Monsieur d'Artagnan!' muttered Mazarin

'This moment come, my lord,' said D'Artagnan.

Mazarin breathed again. His fears were now no longer for his hoard, but for himself. A sort of smile played on his lips.

'Come,' he said, 'you have me in a snare, gentlemen. I confess myself conquered. You wish to ask for liberty, and—I give it you.'

'Oh, my lord!' answered D'Artagnan, 'you are too good; as to our liberty, we have that; we want to ask something else of you.'

'You have your liberty?' repeated Mazarin, in terror.

'Certainly; and on the other hand, my lord, you have lost it, and now, in accordance with the law of war, sir, you must buy it back again.'

Mazarin felt a shiver run through him—a chill even to his heart's core. His piercing look was fixed in vain on the satirical face of the Gascon and the unchanging countenance of Porthos. Both were in shadow and the Sybil of Cuma herself could not have read them.

'To purchase back my liberty?' said the cardinal.

'Yes, my lord.'

'And how much will that cost me, Monsieur d'Artagnan?'

'Zounds, my lord, I don't know yet. We must ask the Comte de la Fère the question. Will your eminence deign to open the door which leads to the count's room, and in ten minutes all will be settled.'

Mazarin started.

'My lord,' said D'Artagnan, 'your eminence sees that we wish to act with all formality and due respect; but I must warn you that we have no time to lose; open the door then, my lord, and be so good as to remember, once for all, that on the slightest attempt to escape or the faintest cry for help, our position being very critical indeed, you must not be angry with us if we go to extremities.'

'Be assured,' answered Mazarin, 'that I shall attempt nothing; I give you my word of honour.'

D'Artagnan made a sign to Porthos to redouble his watchfulness; then turning to Mazarin:

'Now, my lord, let us enter, if you please.'

'I MAKE WAR IN MY OWN WAY'

He called Porthos to look at it.

'Were our object money only,' he said, 'we should be rich directly.'

'How's that?'

'Don't you understand, Porthos? At the bottom of that staircase lies, probably, the cardinal's treasury of which folk tell such wonders, and we should only have to descend, empty a chest, shut the cardinal up in it, double lock it, go away, carrying off as much gold as we could, put back this orange-tree over the place, and no one in the world would ever ask us where our fortune came from—not even the cardinal.'

'It would be a happy hit for clowns to make, but as it seems to be unworthy of two gentlemen— ' said Porthos.

'So I think; and therefore I said, "Were our object money only;" but we want something else,' replied the Gascon.

At the same moment, whilst D'Artagnan was leaning over the aperture to listen, a metallic sound, as if some one was moving a bag of gold, struck on his ear; he started; instantly afterward a door opened and a light played upon the staircase.

Mazarin had left his lamp in the gallery to make people believe that he was walking about, but he had with him a waxlight, to help him to explore his mysterious strong box.

'Faith,' he said, in Italian, as he was reascending the steps and looking at a bag of reals, 'faith, there's enough to pay five councillors of parliament, and two generals in Paris. I am a great captain—that I am! but I make war in my own way.'

The two friends were crouching down, meantime, behind a tub in the side alley.

Mazarin came within three steps of D'Artagnan and pushed a spring in the wall; the slab turned and the orange tree resumed its place.

Then the cardinal put out the waxlight, slipped it into his pocket, and taking up the lantern: 'Now,' he said, 'for Monsieur de la Fère.'

'Very good,' thought D'Artagnan, ''tis our road likewise; we will go together.'

All three set off on their walk, Mazarin taking the middle alley and the friends the side ones.

Chapter LXXXVI

Conferences

MAZARIN turned the lock of a double door, on the threshold of which they found Athos ready to receive his illustrious guests according to the notice Comminges had given him.

On perceiving Mazarin he bowed.

'Your eminence,' he said, 'might have dispensed with your attendants; the honour bestowed on me is too great for me to be unmindful of it.'

'And so, my dear count,' said D'Artagnan, 'his eminence didn't actually insist on our attending him; it is Du Vallon and I who have insisted, and even in a manner somewhat impolite, perhaps, so great was our longing to see you.'

At that voice, that mocking tone, and that familiar gesture, accenting voice and tone, Athos made a bound of surprise.

'D'Artagnan! Porthos!' he exclaimed.

'My very self, dear friend.'

'Me, also!' repeated Porthos.

'What means this?' asked the count.

'It means,' replied Mazarin, trying to smile and biting his lips in the attempt, 'that our parts are changed, and that instead of these gentlemen being my prisoners I am theirs; but, gentlemen, I warn you, unless you kill me, your victory will be of very short duration; people will come to the rescue.'

'Ah! my lord!' cried the Gascon, 'don't threaten! 'tis a bad example. We are so good and gentle to your eminence. Come, let us put aside all rancour and talk pleasantly.'

'There's nothing I wish more,' replied Mazarin. 'But don't think yourselves in a better position than you are. In ensnaring me you have fallen into the trap

yourselves. How are you to get away from here? remember the soldiers and sentinels who guard these doors. Now, I am going to show you how sincere I am.'

'Good,' thought D'Artagnan; 'we must look about us; he's going to play us a trick.'

'I offered you your liberty,' continued the minister; 'will you take it? Before an hour has passed you will be discovered, arrested, obliged to kill me, which would be a crime unworthy of loyal gentlemen like you.'

'He is right,' thought Athos.

And, like every other reflection passing in a mind that entertained none but noble thoughts, this feeling was expressed in his eyes.

'And therefore,' said D'Artagnan, to clip the hope which Athos's tacit adhesion had imparted to Mazarin, 'we shall not proceed to that violence save in the last extremity.'

'If on the contrary,' resumed Mazarin, 'you accept your liberty— '

'Why you, my lord, might take it away from us in less than five minutes afterward; and from my knowledge of you I believe you will so take it away from us.'

'No—on the faith of a cardinal. You do not believe me?'

'My lord, I never believe cardinals who are not priests.'

'Well, on the faith of a minister.'

'You are no longer a minister, my lord; you are a prisoner.'

'Then, on the honour of a Mazarin, as I am and ever shall be, I hope,' said the cardinal.

'Hem,' replied D'Artagnan. 'I have heard speak of a Mazarin who had not much religion when his oaths were in question. I fear he may have been an ancestor of your eminence.'

'Monsieur d'Artagnan, you are a great wit and I am really sorry to be on bad terms with you.'

'My lord, let us come to terms; I ask nothing better.'

'Very well,' said Mazarin, 'if I place you in security, in a manner evident, palpable— '

'Ah! that is another thing,' said Porthos.

'Let us see,' said Athos.

'Let us see,' said D'Artagnan.

Chapter LXXXV

The Oubliettes of Cardinal Mazarin

At first, on arriving at the door through which Mazarin had passed, D'Artagnan tried in vain to open it, but on the powerful shoulder of Porthos being applied to one of the panels, which gave way, D'Artagnan introduced the point of his sword between the bolt and the staple of the lock. The bolt gave way and the door opened.

'As I told you, everything can be attained, Porthos, women and doors, by proceeding with gentleness.'

'You're a great moralist, and that's the fact,' said Porthos.

They entered; behind a glass window, by the light of the cardinal's lantern, which had been placed on the floor in the midst of the gallery, they saw the orange and pomegranate trees of the Castle of Rueil, in long lines, forming one great alley and two smaller side alleys.

'No cardinal!' said D'Artagnan, 'but only his lantern; where the devil, then, is *he?*'

Exploring, however, one of the side wings of the gallery, after making a sign to Porthos to explore the other, he saw, all at once, at his left, a tub containing an orange tree, which had been pushed out of its place and in its place an open aperture.

Ten men would have found difficulty in moving that tub, but by some mechanical contrivance it had turned with the flagstone on which it rested.

D'Artagnan, as we have said, perceived a hole in that place and in this hole the steps of a winding staircase.

'Light the lamp which hangs from the ceiling.'

Then addressing D'Artagnan:

'You know the watchword?' he said.

'Ja!' replied the Gascon, determined to confine himself to this specimen of the German tongue.

'*Tedesco!*' answered the cavalier; '*va bene*.'

And advancing toward the door opposite to that by which he came in, he opened it and disappeared behind it, shutting it as he went.

'Now,' asked Porthos, 'what are we to do?'

'Now we shall make use of your shoulder, friend Porthos, if this door proves to be locked. Everything in its proper time, and all comes right to those who know how to wait patiently. But first barricade the first door well; then we will follow yonder cavalier.'

The two friends set to work and crowded the space before the door with all the furniture in the room, as not only to make the passage impassable, but so to block the door that by no means could it open inward.

'There!' said D'Artagnan, 'we can't be overtaken. Come! forward!'

'In the first place, do you accept?' asked the cardinal.

'Unfold your plan, my lord, and we will see.'

'Take notice that you are shut up—captured.'

'You well know, my lord, that there always remains to us a last resource.'

'What?'

'That of dying together.'

Mazarin shuddered.

'Listen,' he said; 'at the end of yonder corridor is a door, of which I have the key, it leads into the park. Go, and take this key with you; you are active, vigorous, and you have arms. At a hundred steps, on turning to the left, you will find the wall of the park; get over it, and in three leaps you will be on the road and free.'

'Ah! by Jove, my lord,' said D'Artagnan, 'you have well said, but these are only words. Where is the key you speak of?'

'Here it is.'

'Ah, my lord! You will conduct us yourself, then, to that door?'

'Very willingly, if it be necessary to reassure you,' answered the minister, and Mazarin, who was delighted to get off so cheaply, led the way, in high spirits, to the corridor and opened the door.

It led into the park, as the three fugitives perceived by the night breeze which rushed into the corridor and blew the wind into their faces.

'The devil!' exclaimed the Gascon, ''tis a dreadful night, my lord. We don't know the locality, and shall never find the wall. Since your eminence has come so far, come a few steps further; conduct us, my lord, to the wall.'

'Be it so,' replied the cardinal; and walking in a straight line he went to the wall, at the foot of which they all four arrived at the same instant.

'Are you satisfied, gentlemen?' asked Mazarin.

'I think so, indeed; we should be hard to please if we were not. Deuce take it! three poor gentlemen escorted by a prince of the church! Ah! apropos, my lord! you remarked that we were all active, vigorous and armed.'

'Yes.'

'You are mistaken. Monsieur du Vallon and I are the only two who are armed. The count is not; and should we meet with one of your patrol we must defend ourselves.'

''Tis true.'

'Where can we find another sword?' asked Porthos.

'My lord,' said D'Artagnan, 'will lend his, which is of no use to him, to the Comte de la Fère.'

'Willingly,' said the cardinal; 'I will even ask the count to keep it for my sake.'

'I promise you, my lord, never to part with it,' replied Athos.

'Well, well,' cried D'Artagnan, 'this reconciliation is truly touching; have you not tears in your eyes, Porthos?'

'Yes,' said Porthos; 'but I do not know if it is feeling or the wind that makes me weep; I think it is the wind.'

'Now climb up, Athos, quickly,' said D'Artagnan. Athos, assisted by Porthos, who lifted him up like a feather, arrived at the top.

'Now, jump down, Athos.'

Athos jumped and disappeared on the other side of the wall.

'Are you on the ground?' asked D'Artagnan.

'Yes.'

'Without accident?'

'Perfectly safe and sound.'

'Porthos, whilst I get up, watch the cardinal. No, I don't want your help, watch the cardinal.'

'I am watching,' said Porthos. 'Well?'

'You are right; it is more difficult than I thought. Lend me your back—but don't let the cardinal go.'

Porthos lent him his back and D'Artagnan was soon on the summit of the wall, where he seated himself.

Mazarin pretended to laugh.

'Are you there?' asked Porthos.

'Yes, my friend; and now— '

'Now, what?' asked Porthos.

'Now give me the cardinal up here; if he makes any noise stifle him.'

Mazarin wished to call out, but Porthos held him tight and passed him to D'Artagnan, who seized him by the neck and made him sit down by him; then in a menacing tone, he said:

'Sir! jump directly down, close to Monsieur de la Fère, or, on the honour of a gentleman, I'll kill you!'

friend, which was to follow Mazarin in his visit to Athos, he was simply mute. All that he was allowed to say, in case of emergencies, was the proverbial *Der Teufel!*

Bernouin shut the door and went away. When Porthos heard the key turn in the lock he began to be alarmed, lest they should only have exchanged one prison for another.

'Porthos, my friend,' said D'Artagnan, 'don't distrust Providence! Let me meditate and consider.'

'Meditate and consider as much as you like,' replied Porthos, who was now quite out of humour at seeing things take this turn.

'We have walked eight paces,' whispered D'Artagnan, 'and gone up six steps, so hereabouts is the pavilion called the pavilion of the orangery. The Comte de la Fère cannot be far off, only the doors are locked.'

'That is a slight difficulty,' said Porthos, 'and a good push with the shoulders— '

'For God's sake, Porthos my friend, reserve your feats of strength, or they will not have, when needed, the honour they deserve. Have you not heard that some one is coming here?'

'Yes.'

'Well, that some one will open the doors.'

'But, my dear fellow, if that some one recognises us, if that some one cries out, we are lost; for you don't propose, I imagine, that I shall kill that man of the church. That might do if we were dealing with Englishmen or Germans.'

'Oh, may God keep me from it, and you, too!' said D'Artagnan. 'The young king would, perhaps, show us some gratitude; but the queen would never forgive us, and it is she whom we have to consider. And then, besides, the useless blood! never! no, never! I have my plan; let me carry it out and we shall laugh.'

'So much the better,' said Porthos; 'I feel some need of it.'

'Hush!' said D'Artagnan; 'the some one is coming.'

The sound of a light step was heard in the vestibule. The hinges of the door creaked and a man appeared in the dress of a cavalier, wrapped in a brown cloak, with a lantern in one hand and a large beaver hat pulled down over his eyes.

Porthos effaced himself against the wall, but he could not render himself invisible; and the man in the cloak said to him, giving him his lantern:

'Wait a little, Porthos, before crying out; for, on my word, you haven't reached the end,' said the Gascon, in a jesting tone.

'What is to happen?' said Porthos.

'Follow me,' replied D'Artagnan. 'The man who lives to see shall see.'

And slipping through the aperture, he alighted in the court. Porthos followed him by the same road, but with more difficulty and less diligence. They could hear the two soldiers shivering with fear, as they lay bound in the chamber.

Scarcely had the two Frenchmen touched the ground when a door opened and the voice of the *valet-de-chambre* called out:

'Make ready!'

At the same moment the guardhouse was opened and a voice called out:

'La Bruyère and Du Barthois! March!'

'It seems that I am named La Bruyère,' remarked D'Artagnan.

'And I, Du Barthois,' added Porthos.

'Where are you?' asked the *valet-de-chambre*, whose eyes, dazzled by the light, could not clearly distinguish our heroes in the gloom.

'Here we are,' said the Gascon.

'What say you to that, Monsieur du Vallon?' he added in a low tone to Porthos.

'If it but lasts, most capital,' responded Porthos.

These two newly enlisted soldiers marched gravely after the *valet-de-chambre*, who opened the door of the vestibule, then another which seemed to be that of a waiting-room, and showing them two stools:

'Your orders are very simple,' he said; 'don't allow anybody, except one person, to enter here. Do you hear—not a single creature! Obey that person implicitly. On your return you cannot make a mistake. You have only to wait here till I release you.'

D'Artagnan was known to this *valet-de-chambre*, who was no other than Bernouin, and he had during the last six or eight months introduced the Gascon a dozen times to the cardinal. The Gascon, therefore, instead of answering, growled out 'Ja! Ja!' in the most German and the least Gascon accent possible.

As for Porthos, on whom D'Artagnan had impressed the necessity of absolute silence and who did not even now begin to comprehend the scheme of his

'Monsieur, monsieur,' cried Mazarin, 'you are breaking your word to me!'

'I—did I promise you anything, my lord?'

Mazarin groaned.

'You are free,' he said, 'through me; your liberty was my ransom.'

'Agreed; but the ransom of that immense treasure buried under the gallery, to which one descends on pushing a spring hidden in the wall, which causes a tub to turn, revealing a staircase—must not one speak of that a little, my lord?'

'*Diavolo!*' cried Mazarin, almost choked, and clasping his hands; 'I am a lost and ruined man!'

But without listening to his protestations of alarm, D'Artagnan slipped him gently down into the arms of Athos, who stood immovable at the bottom of the wall.

Porthos next made an effort which shook the solid wall, and by the aid of his friend's hand gained the summit.

'I didn't understand it all,' he said, 'but I understand now; how droll it is!'

'You think so? so much the better; but that it may prove laughter-worthy even to the end, let us not lose time.' And he jumped off the wall.

Porthos did the same.

'Attend to monsieur le cardinal, gentlemen,' said D'Artagnan; 'for myself, I will reconnoitre.'

The Gascon then drew his sword and marched as *avant* guard.

'My lord,' he said, 'which way do we go? Think well of your reply, for should your eminence be mistaken, there might ensue most grave results for all of us.'

'Along the wall, sir,' said Mazarin, 'there will be no danger of losing yourselves.'

The three friends hastened on, but in a short time were obliged to slacken the pace. The cardinal could not keep up with them, though with every wish to do so.

Suddenly D'Artagnan touched something warm, which moved.

'Stop! a horse!' he cried; 'I have found a horse!'

'And I, likewise,' said Athos.

'I, too,' said Porthos, who, faithful to the instructions, still held the cardinal's arm.

'There's luck, my lord! just as you were complaining of being tired and obliged to walk.'

But as he spoke the barrel of a pistol was presented at his breast and these words were pronounced:

'Touch it not!'

'Grimaud!' he cried; 'Grimaud! what art thou about? Why, thou art posted here by Heaven!'

'No, sir,' said the honest servant, 'it was Monsieur Aramis who posted me here to take care of the horses.'

'Is Aramis here?'

'Yes, sir; he has been here since yesterday.'

'What are you doing?'

'On the watch— '

'What! Aramis here?' cried Athos.

'At the lesser gate of the castle; he's posted there.'

'Are you a large party?'

'Sixty.'

'Let him know.'

'This moment, sir.'

And believing that no one could execute the commission better than himself, Grimaud set off at full speed; whilst, enchanted at being all together again, the friends awaited his return.

There was no one in the whole group in a bad humour except Cardinal Mazarin.

first, laid him on their bed and bound him with the straps which composed the bed—the bedstead being of oak. This operation proved as great a success as the first.

'There,' said D'Artagnan, 'this is capital! Now let me try on the dress of yonder chap. Porthos, I doubt if you can wear it; but should it be too tight, never mind, you can wear the breastplate and the hat with the red feathers.'

It happened, however, that the second soldier was a Swiss of gigantic proportions, so, save that some few of the seams split, his uniform fitted Porthos perfectly.

They then dressed themselves.

''Tis done!' they both exclaimed at once. 'As to you, comrades,' they said to the men, 'nothing will happen to you if you are discreet; but if you stir you are dead men.'

The soldiers were complaisant; they had found the grasp of Porthos pretty powerful and that it was no joke to fight against it.

'Now,' said D'Artagnan, 'you wouldn't be sorry to understand the plot, would you, Porthos?'

'Well, no, not very.'

'Well, then, we shall go down into the court.'

'Yes.'

'We shall take the place of those two fellows.'

'Well?'

'We will walk back and forth.'

'That's a good idea, for it isn't warm.'

'In a moment the *valet-de-chambre* will call the guard, as he did yesterday and the day before.'

'And we shall answer?'

'No, on the contrary, we shall not answer.'

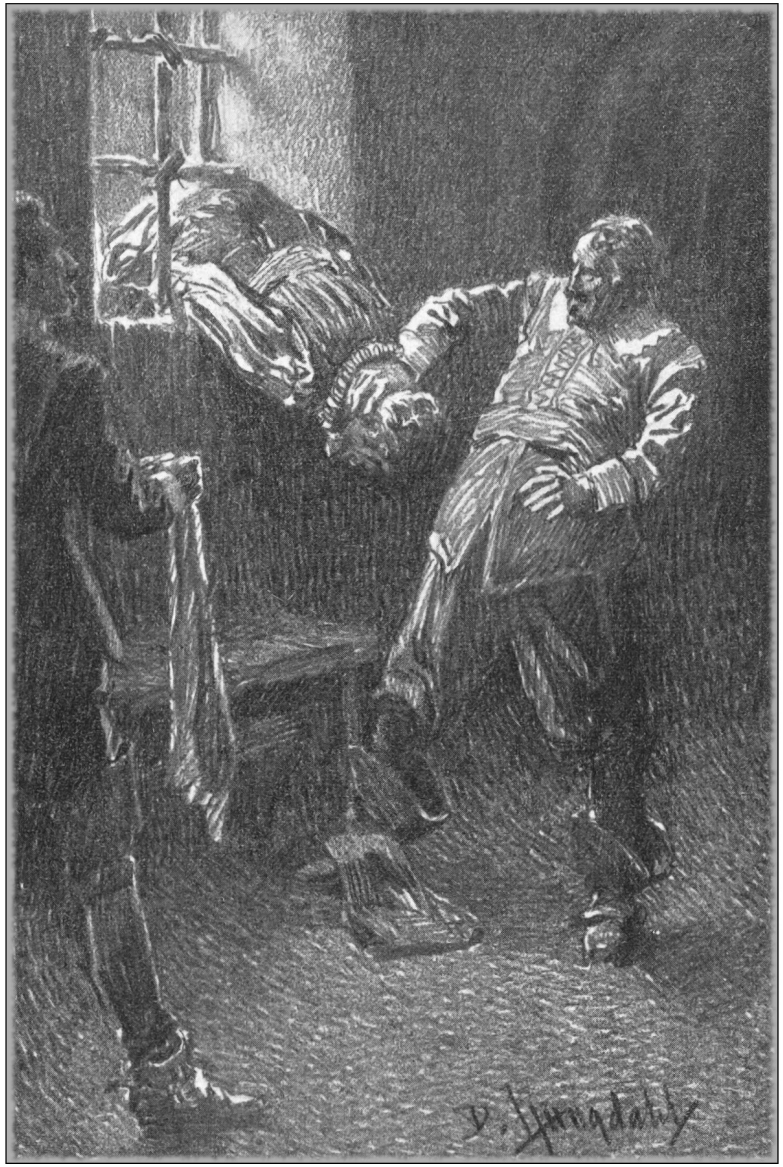
'As you please; I don't insist on answering.'

'We will not answer, then; we will simply settle our hats on our heads and we will escort his eminence.'

'Where shall we escort him?'

'Where he is going—to visit Athos. Do you think Athos will be sorry to see us?'

'Oh!' cried Porthos, 'oh! I understand.'



His hand of iron grasped the soldier's throat

Chapter LXXXVII

Thinking that Porthos Will Be At Last a Baron, and D'Artagnan a Captain

At the expiration of ten minutes Aramis arrived, accompanied by Grimaud and eight or ten followers. He was excessively delighted and threw himself into his friends' arms.

'You are free, my brothers! free without my aid! and I shall have succeeded in doing nothing for you in spite of all my efforts.'

'Do not be unhappy, dear friend, on that account; if you have done nothing as yet, you will do something soon,' replied Athos.

'I had well concerted my plans,' pursued Aramis; 'the coadjutor gave me sixty men; twenty guard the walls of the park, twenty the road from Rueil to Saint Germain, twenty are dispersed in the woods. Thus I was able, thanks to the strategic disposition of my forces, to intercept two couriers from Mazarin to the queen.'

Mazarin listened intently.

'But,' said D'Artagnan, 'I trust that you honourably sent them back to monsieur le cardinal!'

'Ah, yes!' said Aramis, 'toward him I should be very likely to practice such delicacy of sentiment! In one of the despatches the cardinal declares to the queen that the treasury is empty and that her majesty has no more money. In the other he announces that he is about to transport his prisoners to Melun, since Rueil seemed to him not sufficiently secure. You can understand, dear

friend, with what hope I was inspired by that last letter. I placed myself in ambuscade with my sixty men; I encircled the castle; the riding horses I entrusted to Grimaud and I awaited your coming out, which I did not expect till to-morrow, and I didn't hope to free you without a skirmish. You are free to-night, without fighting; so much the better! How did you manage to escape that scoundrel Mazarin? You must have much reason to complain of him.'

'Not very much,' said D'Artagnan.

'Really!'

'I might even say that we have some reason to praise him.'

'Impossible!'

'Yes, really; it is owing to him that we are free.'

'Owing to him?'

'Yes, he had us conducted into the orangery by Monsieur Bernouin, his *valet-de-chambre*, and from there we followed him to visit the Comte de la Fère. Then he offered us our liberty and we accepted it. He even went so far as to show us the way out; he led us to the park wall, which we climbed over without accident, and then we fell in with Grimaud.'

'Well!' exclaimed Aramis, 'this will reconcile me to him; but I wish he were here that I might tell him that I did not believe him capable of so noble an act.'

'My lord,' said D'Artagnan, no longer able to contain himself, 'allow me to introduce to you the Chevalier d'Herblay, who wishes—as you may have heard—to offer his congratulations to your eminence.'

And he retired, discovering Mazarin, who was in great confusion, to the astonished gaze of Aramis.

'Ho! ho!' exclaimed the latter, 'the cardinal! a glorious prize! Halloo! halloo! friends! to horse! to horse!'

Several horsemen ran quickly to him.

'Zounds!' cried Aramis, 'I may have done some good; so, my lord, deign to receive my most respectful homage! I will lay a wager that 'twas that Saint Christopher, Porthos, who performed this feat! Apropos! I forgot— ' and he gave some orders in a low voice to one of the horsemen.

'I think it will be wise to set off,' said D'Artagnan.

'Yes; but I am expecting some one, a friend of Athos.'

'A friend!' exclaimed the count.

'And here he comes, by Jupiter! galloping through the bushes.'

'And I think a glass of wine will not be disagreeable to you?'

'A glass of wine will be extremely welcome.'

'The fish bites—the fish bites!' whispered the Gascon to Porthos.

'I understand,' said Porthos.

'A bottle, perhaps?'

'A whole bottle? Yes, sir.'

'A whole bottle, if you will drink my health.'

'Willingly,' answered the soldier.

'Come, then, and take it, friend,' said the Gascon.

'With all my heart. How convenient that there's a bench here. Egad! one would think it had been placed here on purpose.'

'Get on it; that's it, friend.'

And D'Artagnan coughed.

That instant the arm of Porthos fell. His hand of iron grasped, quick as lightning, firm as a pair of blacksmith's pincers, the soldier's throat. He raised him, almost stifling him as he drew him through the aperture, at the risk of flaying him in the passage. He then laid him down on the floor, where D'Artagnan, after giving him just time enough to draw his breath, gagged him with his long scarf; and the moment he had done so began to undress him with the promptitude and dexterity of a man who had learned his business on the field of battle. Then the soldier, gagged and bound, was placed upon the hearth, the fire of which had been previously extinguished by the two friends.

'Here's a sword and a dress,' said Porthos.

'I take them,' said D'Artagnan, 'for myself. If you want another uniform and sword you must play the same trick over again. Stop! I see the other soldier issue from the guardroom and come toward us.'

'I think,' replied Porthos, 'it would be imprudent to attempt the same manœuvre again; it is said that no man can succeed twice in the same way, and a failure would be ruinous. No; I will go down, seize the man unawares and bring him to you ready gagged.'

'That is better,' said the Gascon.

'Be ready,' said Porthos, as he slipped through the opening.

He did as he said. Porthos seized his opportunity, caught the next soldier by his neck, gagged him and pushed him like a mummy through the bars into the room, and entered after him. Then they undressed him as they had done the